WISEConv: Closing the Sparsity-to-Speedup Gap in Masked Convolution with Worklist-Driven Execution

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Abstract

Masked convolution promises lower latency by computing only positions an upstream policy marks active, yet existing paths keep either throughput (tile skipping) or useful-compute ratio (gather-scatter), never both, failing to turn sparsity into proportional speedup. Contrary to the expectation that scattered work breaks dense efficiency, we find that restricting a dense tiled pipeline to scattered positions largely preserves per-tile throughput: irregularity is confined to row-level indirection outside the reduction loop, leaving channel-contiguous access and weight-tile reuse identical to dense. We therefore present WISEConv, which drives the unchanged dense pipeline with an active-output worklist. The worklist brings two costs dense execution never pays. Construction cost stays fixed per layer shape as compute shrinks with the active ratio, so WISEConv builds the worklist in one mask-space pass and reuses it across compatible operators. The worklist length, visible only on the device, varies per frame and layer and shifts the best tile configuration, so WISEConv performs on-device cost-aware configuration switching, weighing each candidate's gain against its selection cost. Across six GPUs and four workloads, WISEConv achieves a 2.20× geometric-mean latency reduction over the fastest baseline per workload-platform pair and reduces energy by 60.8–90.1% versus dense execution on embedded GPUs.

Keywords: Sparse convolution, dynamic spatial sparsity, GPU runtime, deep learning systems, efficient inference

1 Introduction

Dense convolution dominates per-frame latency in vision tasks where reaction time decides the outcome [3, 12, 45], such as a car avoiding a pedestrian stepping out of occlusion [26], a drone dodging an obstacle [13], or a robot returning a table-tennis ball [9] (Figure 1). Yet on a given input much of that computation is spatially redundant. A common remedy is masked convolution: an upstream policy marks spatially active positions on the dense feature grid, and a dedicated sparse convolution operator updates only these positions in the dense output. The mask may derive from event-camera increments [10, 28], temporal differences [20, 34], or learned spatial gates [25, 42]. These mask sources promise large reductions in convolution work, yet existing masked-convolution systems [10, 25, 34, 42] rarely translate the sparsity into proportional latency reduction.

Dense GPU convolution obtains high *throughput* (operations per second) from coordinate-driven, tiled execution.

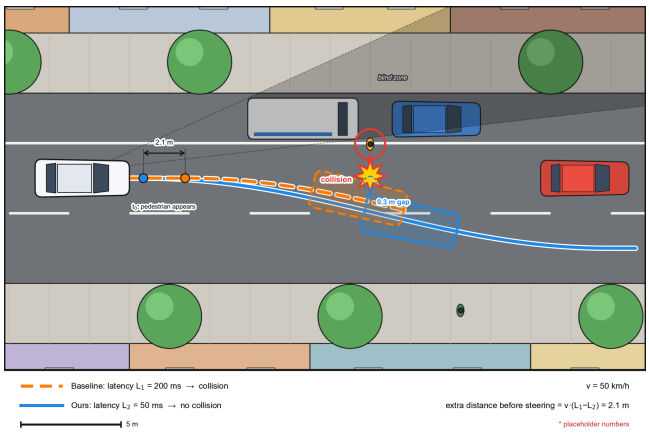


Figure 1. Perception latency decides whether a vehicle can react in time: a pedestrian steps out from a blind zone, and the vehicle whose detector returns later travels farther before steering.

Each tile enumerates a contiguous block of output coordinates; those coordinates fix each output position's receptive field and write location, while the reduction over channels and kernel offsets follows a regular datapath with coalesced loads and weight-tile reuse. In masked convolution, reducing latency proportionally requires sustaining this throughput while achieving a high *useful-compute ratio* (the fraction of issued operations that produce needed outputs), but the per-frame position selection imposed by the mask conflicts with the contiguous coordinate assumption that sustains throughput, placing these two axes in tension.

Existing systems sacrifice one axis for the other. *Gather-scatter* [25, 42, 46] extracts exactly the active positions into a packed representation, computes, and scatters the results back, but is bottlenecked by the memory traffic of materializing their receptive fields. *Tile skipping* [10, 20, 34, 36] suppresses tiles that are entirely inactive and retains the dense pipeline, but wastes computation on partially active tiles. On an RTX 3080 running YOLOv8m [22] at batch 4 under temporal difference masks [34], 82.2% of convolution work is unnecessary. Gather-scatter sustains only 43.7% of the dense pipeline's throughput, reducing latency by just 59.3%; tile skipping reaches higher throughput but wastes 32.6% of issued operations, reducing latency by 54.3%, slower than gather-scatter despite its throughput advantage (§2.2).

We find that redirecting a dense tiled pipeline to compute only scattered active positions achieves both a high useful-compute ratio and the throughput of dense execution. We

collect these positions into a worklist and characterize (§3) the resulting tiled execution on a desktop and an embedded GPU, identifying why: because the input stays a dense grid, the irregularity reduces to one index per output row, outside the reduction loop that drives coalesced channel loads and weight-tile reuse, so per-tile throughput matches dense execution. When the tile configuration follows the worklist length, convolution time is affine in the active ratio with a slope matching the dense marginal cost; the residual gap is an intercept of 5.6–17.4% of dense time per layer (median per GPU and precision), dominated by kernel launch latency and fixed per-tile stalls such as barriers, not by throughput loss.

While this finding establishes that worklist-driven tiled execution can sustain both axes, closing the gap end to end requires solving two further challenges. First, *worklist construction cost*: deriving the worklist from the mask requires scanning the whole grid and costs time independent of the active count, so construction's share of latency grows as activity falls and accumulates when every layer rebuilds. Second, *worklist consumption efficiency*: the affine property holds for a given number of active positions under a matching tile configuration, but in deployment this number is visible only on the device after construction and shifts across frames and layers. Reading it back to the host stalls the per-frame path; adapting on the device avoids the stall but incurs a non-negligible cost per decision point (§3).

Based on these findings, we present WISEConv (**W**orklist-dr**I**ven ma**S**k**E**d **Conv**olution), which drives the dense tiled pipeline with an active-output worklist to achieve both a high useful-compute ratio and high throughput by co-designing worklist construction and consumption. To reduce construction cost, a single mask-space pass fuses output-mask propagation with per-tile compaction, operating on only mask and coordinate metadata; compatible operators reuse the worklist instead of reconstructing it. To sustain consumption efficiency, a persistent compute grid consumes the worklist without host synchronization, and a cost-aware selection mechanism adapts the tile configuration per frame, adding a candidate to a layer only where its expected gain exceeds the selection overhead.

This paper makes the following contributions:

- We characterize worklist-driven tiled execution, identifying why computing scattered active positions preserves dense-level throughput and where the remaining gap comes from. These findings motivate and constrain the design (§3).
- We present WISEConv, which co-designs worklist construction, worklist-driven tiled compute, and cost-aware tile selection to jointly sustain high useful-compute ratio and high throughput (§4).
- We evaluate WISEConv on four workloads across six GPUs. WISEConv achieves a 2.18× (FP32) and 2.22× (FP16) geometric-mean speedup over the fastest baseline per pair, and reduces energy by 60.8–90.1% relative to dense execution on embedded GPUs (§6).

2 Background and Motivation

2.1 Masked Convolution

Convolution runs inside the perception-action loop of many vision applications [3, 38, 43, 45, 49], where per-frame inference latency bounds system responsiveness [11–13, 21]. To cut this latency, masked convolution exploits dynamic spatial sparsity: an upstream policy emits a spatial mask, and the operator computes only the marked positions. The mask comes from sources including event-camera increments [10, 28], temporal residuals between video frames [4, 20, 33, 34, 44], or learned input-dependent gates [15, 25, 42, 46]. These sources differ in sensing modality and policy, but all expose the same dynamic spatial sparsity on a dense 2D feature grid, so a single masked-convolution runtime serves them all.

Masked convolution retains dense tensor layouts and arithmetic, restricting only which output coordinates are computed (Figure 2). It operates on an input feature tensor $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^{H_{in}\times W_{in}\times C_{in}}$, a weight tensor $\mathbf{f} \in \mathbb{R}^{k\times k\times C_{in}\times C_{out}}$ of kernel size k, and an output $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^{H_{out}\times W_{out}\times C_{out}}$ on a coordinate grid $\mathcal{G} = \{1, \ldots, H_{out}W_{out}\}$, where each coordinate $p \in \mathcal{G}$ indexes a spatial position (h, w) and has a $k \times k$ receptive field $\mathcal{N}(p)$ in $\mathbf{x}$. An upstream policy marks the coordinates to compute in an output mask $M_{out} \in \{0,1\}^{H_{out}\times W_{out}}$. Spatial gating predicts M_{out} directly; event and temporal policies instead supply an input mask $M_{in} \in \{0,1\}^{H_{in}\times W_{in}}$ whose active positions propagate their influence along the receptive field, so p stays active whenever any input in $\mathcal{N}(p)$ is active,

$$M_{out}[p] = \begin{cases} 1, & \exists\, r \in \mathcal{N}(p) \text{ s.t. } M_{in}[r] = 1, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

M_{out} thus identifies the output positions that the execution path is required to compute, each by aggregating $\mathbf{x}$ over $\mathcal{N}(p)$ with the weights $\mathbf{f}$.

An execution path issues computation over a sequence of position slots C, where each slot is drawn from $\mathcal{G} \cup \{\perp\}$;

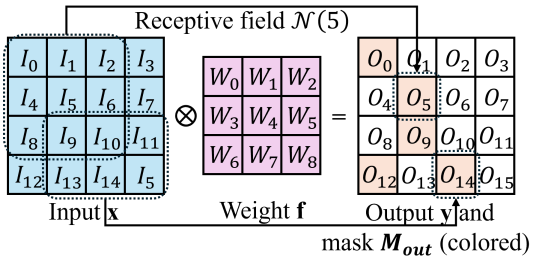


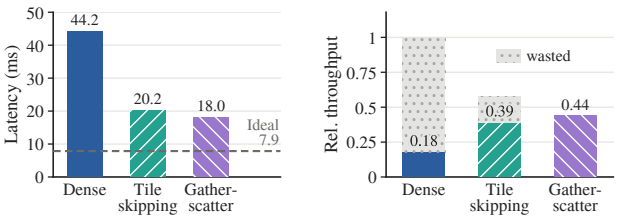
Figure 2. Masked convolution: each output O_p aggregates its receptive field $\mathcal{N}(p)$ in $\mathbf{x}$ with the weights $\mathbf{f}$; colored outputs are active in M_{out}.

$\perp$ denotes a padding slot that carries no output coordinate. The path must satisfy the *coverage contract*: every active coordinate is included, $\{p : M_{out}[p] = 1\} \subseteq \{c \in C : c \neq \perp\}$. For each non-$\perp$ slot $p \in C$ it computes

$$\mathbf{y}[p] = \sum_{i=1}^{k^2} \mathbf{x}[\mathcal{N}_i(p)]\, \mathbf{f}_i, \tag{2}$$

where $\mathcal{N}_i(p)$ is the i-th position in $\mathcal{N}(p)$ and $\mathbf{f}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{C_{in} \times C_{out}}$ the corresponding weight slice. How unrequested positions are treated is policy-specific: event and temporal execution retains prior state, while learned gating merges results into a residual. Coverage is therefore the operator-level correctness condition; the policy determines the treatment of all other positions. Beyond coverage, a path may issue inactive or $\perp$ slots; dense convolution is the extreme where $\{c \in C : c \neq \perp\} = \mathcal{G}$. The policy fixes the accuracy and required work.

2.2 The Sparsity-to-Latency Gap



(a) Latency per batch (b) Relative throughput

Figure 3. YOLOv8m [22] at batch 4 on WildTrack 640 and RTX 3080 (FP32) under the DeltaCNN [34] temporal difference masks, comparing cuDNN (Dense), DeltaCNN tile skipping, and MMCV gather-scatter [6]; all paths consume the same masks. (a) End-to-end latency per batch step; the dashed line (Ideal) is dense latency scaled by the active ratio of the convolution work. (b) Throughput normalized to dense raw throughput. Bar height is raw throughput T; the colored share is effective throughput T_{eff} (labeled) and the dotted share is spent on inactive positions.

Existing systems execute a mask along one of two paths. *Tile skipping* [10, 20, 27, 33, 36, 44] (Figure 4) inherits the dense pipeline's tile-based computation without additional metadata passes, skipping a tile only when all its coordinates are inactive and otherwise computing the whole tile; DeltaCNN [34] fuses a selective path into the kernel, taken when a tile is estimated to be mostly empty, to cut wasted work. *Gather-scatter* [25, 46] (Figure 5) instead abandons the dense pipeline: it extracts exactly the active coordinates into a packed representation, runs a separate GEMM, and scatters the results back, removing the inactive arithmetic but adding extraction, irregular access, and writeback overhead; DynConv [42] adopts a model structure suited to gather-scatter, where one gather feeds several consecutive layers before a single scatter, amortizing that overhead.

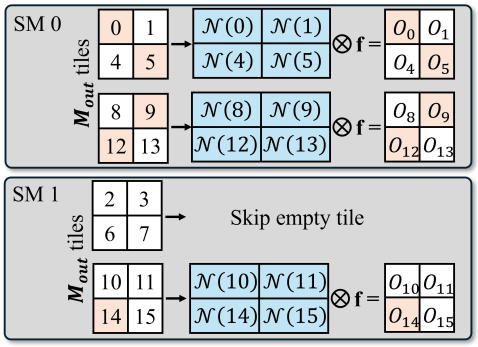


Figure 4. Tile skipping on the example of Figure 2. An all-inactive tile is skipped; other tiles run in full, so their inactive (white) outputs are wasted computation.

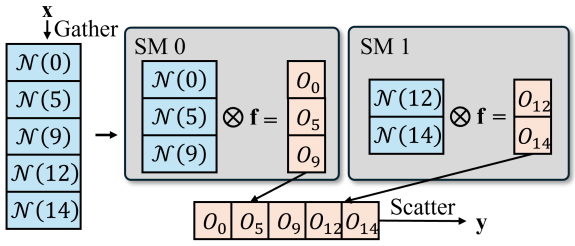


Figure 5. Gather-scatter on the example of Figure 2. Receptive fields of active outputs are gathered into a packed buffer, computed, and scattered back into $\mathbf{y}$; the extra gather and scatter overhead, not the computation, dominate its latency.

A policy fixes the active ratio α, defined as the fraction of output-grid positions marked active, whereas a concrete execution path determines the useful-compute ratio η, defined as the fraction of issued slots that correspond to required outputs:

$$\alpha = \frac{\|M_{out}\|_0}{|\mathcal{G}|}, \quad \eta = \frac{\|M_{out}\|_0}{|C|}. \tag{3}$$

For $|C| > 0$, an ideal path achieves $\eta = 1$ by issuing only required outputs; dense convolution, which issues the entire grid, has $\eta \approx \alpha$. An execution path also determines its throughput T, which combines with η to yield the effective throughput T_{eff}:

$$T = \frac{2|C|k^2 C_{in} C_{out}}{t}, \quad T_{\text{eff}} = \eta T. \tag{4}$$

where t denotes the latency of the execution path, including auxiliary mask and coordinate processing, k is the filter kernel size, and C_{in} and C_{out} are the input and output channel counts respectively. The factor of two counts each multiply-accumulate as two FLOPs. Consequently, T_{eff} directly characterizes the processing rate of required outputs and therefore determines the realized latency.

Figure 3 makes this concrete on RTX 3080 for YOLOv8m [22] at batch 4 under temporal difference masks [34], where 82.2%

of convolution work is unnecessary. Tile skipping holds throughput at 57.8% of dense but at a useful-compute ratio of only 67.4%; gather-scatter lifts the useful-compute ratio to one, yet extraction traffic collapses its throughput to 43.7% of dense. Neither path efficiently converts the GPU's capability into effective throughput.

2.3 Distinction from Related Sparse Execution

WISEConv differs from other sparse-execution work in representation and sparsity type. 3D sparse-convolution systems [8, 19, 37, 40, 41, 47] operate on sparse point-cloud coordinates; sparse matrix multiplication [14, 17, 35] targets structural sparsity in graphs or pruned weights; structured weight pruning [30] exploits fixed patterns; sparse-format compilers [24, 48] encode sparsity in tensor formats. DPACS [18] targets the same dynamic 2D spatial sparsity but designs a custom dataflow accelerator to handle the resulting irregular access patterns.

Row-indexed operand loads are an established implementation technique: CUTLASS fuses gather and scatter into GEMM [1], mixture-of-experts kernels read tokens through scattered indices inside a grouped GEMM [16, 39], and the Blackwell TMA gathers rows by index [31]. These kernels use the indirection to avoid a copy, but do not characterize its cost against the dense kernel, nor face the overlapping receptive fields that scattering convolution outputs disrupts. We show that for convolution on a dense input grid the indirection leaves the reduction identical to dense, so the residual gap is a per-layer fixed cost rather than lost throughput (§3).

3 Characterizing Worklist-Driven Convolution

Before presenting WISEConv, we characterize what worklist-driven tiled convolution achieves and where it falls short. We study the compute stage (a dense tiled implicit-GEMM kernel redirected to compute only positions from a worklist; §4.4) and the construction stage (a mask-to-worklist pass) separately, so that each finding belongs to the execution model, not to a particular implementation. FP16 uses `mma.sync` tensor cores; FP32 is a SIMT kernel of the same structure. Each configuration is timed in isolation inside CUDA graphs on RTX 3080 (68 SMs) and Jetson AGX Orin (16 SMs) at locked clocks, using YOLOv8m [22] at batch 1 on WildTrack [5] unless noted otherwise. Dense reference: the faster of the same kernel on the full grid and cuDNN non-Winograd.

3.1 Affine Latency Requires Following the Length

A worklist kernel issues only active outputs ($\eta \approx 1$), so proportional speedup means keeping dense throughput. When we grant the kernel its best configuration at every worklist length, its latency averaged across layers is affine in α, well fitted by $t/t_{\text{dense}} = a\alpha + b$. On RTX 3080, $a = 0.794$, $b = 0.258$ (FP32) and $a = 0.643$, $b = 0.417$ (FP16); on AGX Orin, $a = 0.917$, $b = 0.085$ (FP32) and $a = 0.830$, $b = 0.267$ (FP16), with per-layer R^2 medians of 0.97–0.995 (Figure 6). The slope a matches the dense marginal cost; the entire departure from proportional is the intercept b, a per-layer fixed cost analyzed in §3.4.

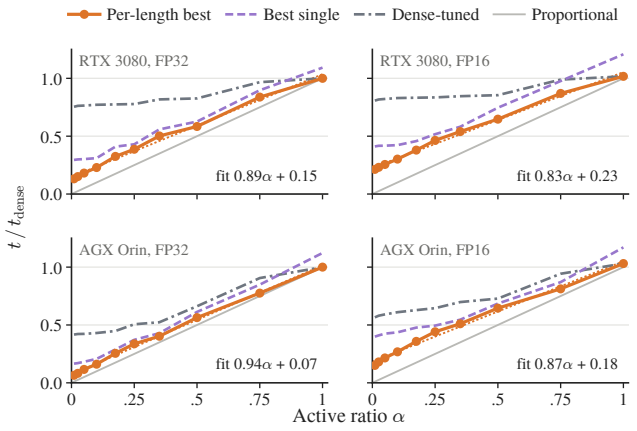


Figure 6. Convolution time averaged across the layers of YOLOv8m at batch 1, normalized to dense, against the active ratio, per GPU and precision. The per-length best (markers) takes the fastest configuration at each worklist length, with its affine fit dotted; the best single configuration minimizes the expected time over a uniform active ratio; the dense-tuned configuration is the fastest at $\alpha = 1$. Gray: proportional.

This affine behavior holds only when the configuration follows the worklist length. The dense-tuned configuration runs 2.3× (FP32) and 1.6× (FP16) slower than the per-length best at low activity on RTX 3080, and 4.0× and 1.9× on AGX Orin (Figure 6): large tiles amortize weight loads over many rows, but when rows are few, smaller tiles and split-K shorten the chain each SM executes. The best single configuration under a uniform worklist-length assumption narrows the gap but remains XX–XX% slower than the per-length oracle.

Insight 1. *The latency of worklist-driven tiled convolution is affine in the active ratio at dense marginal cost only when the tile configuration follows the worklist length.*

3.2 Why Per-Tile Throughput Matches Dense

The worklist changes only the base address of each row; under a channels-last layout, the reduction loop over k^2 taps and channel slices keeps the dense kernel's addressing, so channel coalescing and weight-tile reuse are untouched. Counters confirm it: a worklist tile executes the same instructions as a dense tile (within 0.5%), with sectors per request matching dense (Figure 7a). DRAM traffic does not increase significantly over dense: neighboring active positions share overlapping receptive fields, and L2 absorbs the redundant

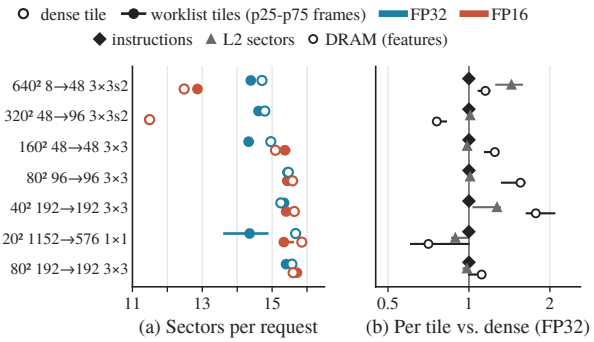


Figure 7. A worklist tile against a dense tile of the same configuration on representative layers (RTX 3080, Nsight Compute, cold L2). (a) Global-load sectors per request of the dense tile and of the worklist tiles of real frames (dot: median frame; bar: 25th to 75th percentile frames). (b) Per-tile instructions, L2 read sectors, and DRAM bytes of the features (weights excluded, as they are read once per launch), relative to the dense tile (FP32).

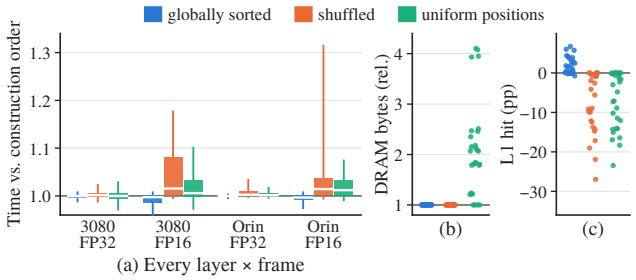


Figure 8. The same worklist in four orders with the same length and tile. (a) Time relative to the construction order over every layer and captured frame (box: 25th to 75th percentile; whiskers: 5th to 95th; line: median). (b) DRAM read bytes and (c) L1 hit rate change on representative layers (one dot per layer, GPU, and precision; cold L2). Uniform positions draw the same number of positions uniformly over the grid, without the spatial clustering of the mask.

accesses. L2 traffic is higher than dense because the worklist's spatial scattering reduces tile-local reuse, but this does not surface at DRAM (Figure 7b).

Insight 2. *Irregularity is confined to row-level indirection outside the reduction loop, leaving channel-contiguous access and weight-tile reuse identical to dense execution.*

3.3 Order Is a Second-Order Effect

Scattered worklist entries could hurt L1 reuse by placing positions with non-overlapping receptive fields into the same tile. We test this by comparing three orderings of the same worklist: tile-local (dense traversal order within each spatial tile, arbitrary order across tiles), globally sorted in dense traversal order, and randomly shuffled. Across 3,560 layer-frame samples on RTX 3080, global sorting runs at 0.999× the tile-local order (median) and shuffling at 1.004–1.007×; model-level totals are within 2.2%. All three move identical DRAM bytes; the difference is only in L1 hit rate. On AGX Orin, shuffling slows wide early layers by up to 1.33× because the extra L1-to-L2 traffic is exposed by the lower L2 bandwidth, but the tile-local order already recovers everything a global order would (0.993–0.999×).

Insight 3. *Worklist order has negligible impact on DRAM traffic; a tile-local order recovers all of a global order's benefit.*

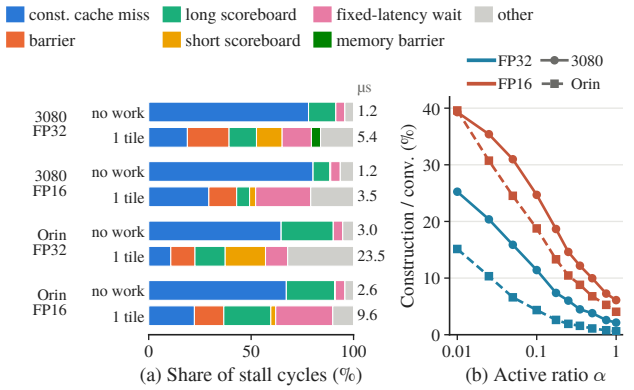


Figure 9. The two per-layer fixed costs. (a) Warp stall reasons of one launch of the compute kernel with no work and with a single tile (median share over representative layers, Nsight Compute), and its time per launch. (b) Construction time over the per-length-best convolution time of the whole model, against the active ratio of the masks.

3.4 The Residual Gap Is a Per-Layer Fixed Cost

The intercept b consists of launch latency and a single-tile dependent chain. An empty kernel spends 92% of its stall cycles on constant-cache misses (the parameters are cold); a single tile adds barriers and, with split-K, memory fences, with long-scoreboard stalls at only 6–27% (Table 1). The intercept is 10–17% of a median YOLOv8m layer's dense time on RTX 3080, smaller on AGX Orin where each layer is larger relative to the device.

Construction adds a second fixed cost. Each mask-to-worklist pass takes 1.7–3.2 μs on RTX 3080 and 4.2–23.6 μs on AGX Orin, nearly independent of activity (Figure 9b, right axis). As the oracle convolution time shrinks with α, construction's share rises (Figure 9b, left axis): from XX% at $\alpha = 0.5$ to XX% at $\alpha = 0.1$ on RTX 3080 FP32.

Insight 4. *The residual gap comes from per-layer fixed costs independent of activity: launch latency in the compute intercept, and near-constant construction time.*

Table 1. Composition of the intercept: time per launch with no work and with a single tile (median and range over representative layers), the two largest stall reasons of the single tile, and the intercept of the per-layer affine fit relative to dense time (median over layers).

	RTX 3080		AGX Orin	
	FP32	FP16	FP32	FP16
No work (μs)	1.2	1.2	3.0	2.6
1 tile (μs)	5.4	3.5	23.5	9.6
range	4.6–9.2	3.0–4.3	11.1–37.1	7.8–15.2
Top stall	barrier	const. miss	short sb.	wait
share (%)	19.9	29.3	19.2	27.5
Second stall	const. miss	wait	long sb.	long sb.
share (%)	18.5	26.8	14.4	22.6
b/t_{dense}	10.0%	14.9%	5.6%	17.4%

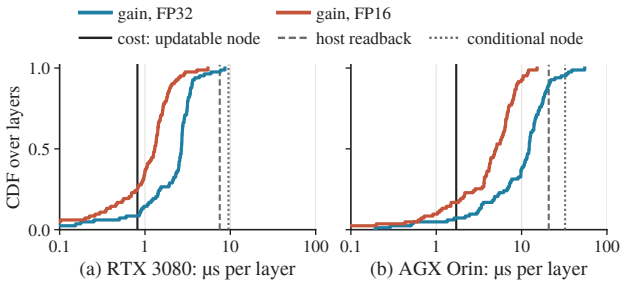


Figure 10. Per-layer gain of selecting the configuration per worklist length over the best single configuration on the real trace (CDF over layers), against the per-layer cost of each selection mechanism on the same GPU.

3.5 Following the Length Is Not Free

Insight 1 requires the configuration to follow the worklist length, but the length exists only on the device and changes at every layer of every frame. Every mechanism that selects a kernel from it pays per decision point: reading the length back to the host stalls the per-frame path; a device-updatable kernel node costs 1.9 μs per layer on RTX 3080; a conditional graph node costs 9.5 μs (RTX 3080) and 17–19 μs (AGX Orin). These costs are comparable to the median per-layer gain from per-length selection (Figure 10), so the number of candidates and selection points a frame can afford is bounded by the mechanism, not by the oracle.

Insight 5. *Every mechanism for following the worklist length incurs a per-decision-point cost often comparable to the per-layer gain from adaptation.*

Insights 4 and 5 together mean that current hardware cannot reach the oracle affine line without trading selection cost against adaptation gain; §6.5 discusses the hardware support that would remove this trade-off.

4 WISEConv Design

4.1 Overview

WISEConv exploits the fact that dense tiled convolution is driven by output coordinates: each coordinate determines the receptive-field reads and output write, while the reduction over channels and kernel offsets remains regular. Replacing the dense coordinate sequence with an active-output worklist introduces position-level selectivity into the tiled pipeline without altering the reduction datapath (Figure 11d).

Translating this into end-to-end latency reduction requires co-designing two stages. The construction stage (§4.2) derives the worklist from the mask, and compatible operators reuse it to avoid repeated construction (§4.3). The compute stage (§4.4) consumes the worklist through a persistent grid with the dense reduction datapath; because the worklist length varies per frame and is visible only on the device, a cost-aware mechanism selects the tile configuration without host involvement (§4.5).

4.2 Tile-Local Worklist Construction

Constructing a tight schedule already requires a scan of the output grid, but the resulting coordinates must also retain enough spatial structure for efficient consumption. Globally stable compaction preserves the complete dense traversal order but requires a prefix scan or another pass to obtain device-wide offsets; per-coordinate appends avoid that coordination but scatter neighboring positions. Materializing active receptive fields, as gather-scatter does, regularizes the compute input at the cost of feature traffic proportional to the active count and $k^2 C_{in}$. The useful middle ground is therefore a metadata-only schedule with local rather than global ordering.

WISEConv realizes this with contiguous, tile-local worklist segments. Because the number of active positions is not known before the pass, it preallocates a coordinate buffer with capacity $|\mathcal{G}| = H_{out} W_{out}$, the static upper bound on $|\mathcal{W}|$. Algorithm 1 details the resulting single pass. Line 1 initializes the device-resident length counter. Lines 2–7 partition the output grid into $B_\tau \times B_\tau$ construction tiles, derive the corresponding entries of M_{out} using Eq. 1, and compact each tile's active coordinates into a local sequence $\mathcal{P}_\tau$ in dense-traversal order. When a learned gate supplies M_{out} directly [25, 42], Lines 4–5 are omitted and Line 7 compacts the supplied mask. Lines 8–11 count the compacted coordinates, atomically reserve $[\text{base}, \text{base} + n_\tau)$ from the counter, and copy $\mathcal{P}_\tau$ into that interval. After all tiles complete, the reserved intervals collectively store $\mathcal{W}$, and the counter records $n_{\mathcal{W}}$. Because the layer shape fixes the buffer capacity and launch geometry while only the device observes the data-dependent length, construction requires no runtime allocation or host-visible active count.

To relate the worklist to the useful-compute ratio of Eq. 3, we insert its length $n_{\mathcal{W}}$ between the required-position count

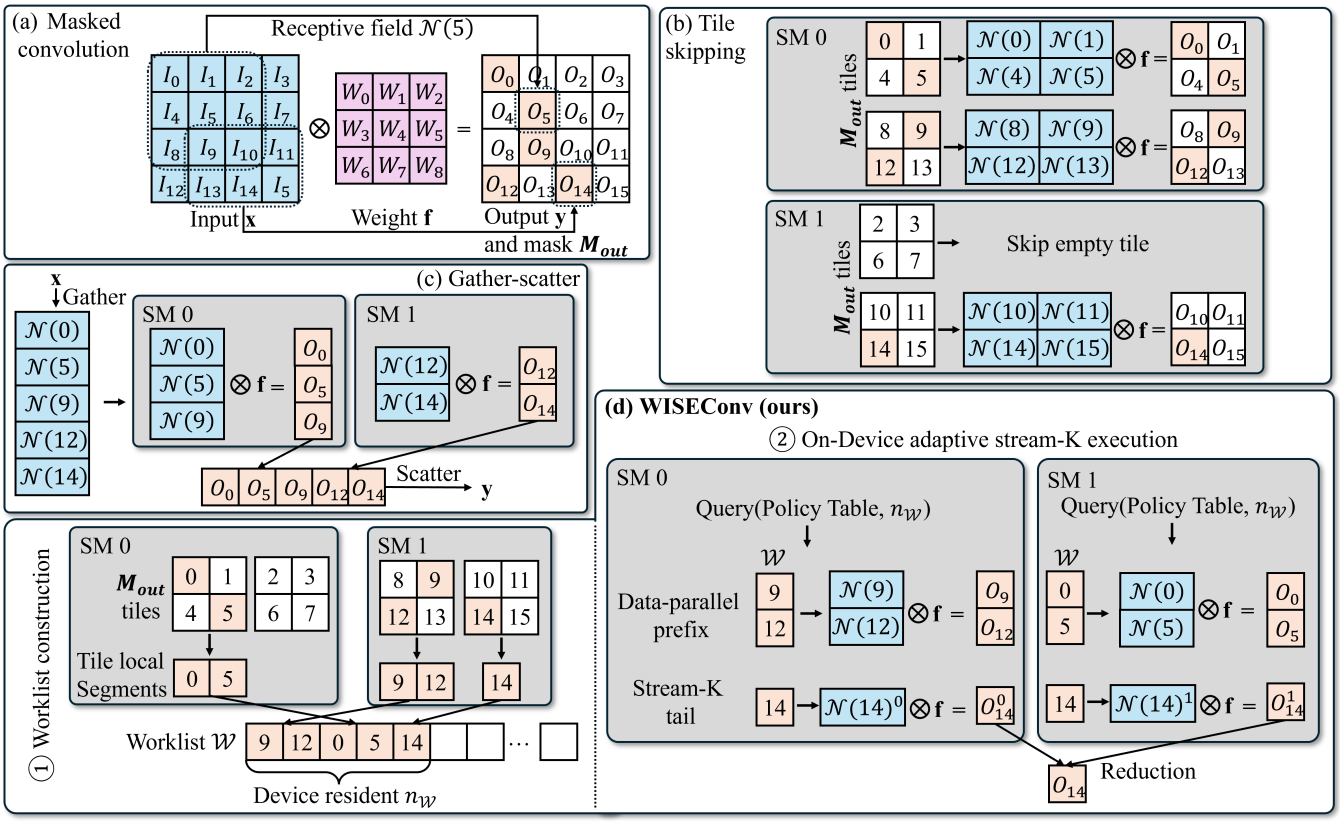


Figure 11. Overview of WISEConv and baseline execution paths. (a) Masked convolution. (b) Tile skipping. (c) Gather-scatter. (d) WISEConv: ① constructs a tile-local worklist from the mask, ② consumes it via worklist-driven tiled execution.

and the issued-slot count. For $n_{\mathcal{W}} > 0$,

$$\eta = \underbrace{\frac{\|M_{out}\|_0}{n_{\mathcal{W}}}}_{\eta_{\text{construct}}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{n_{\mathcal{W}}}{|C|}}_{\eta_{\text{compute}}} . \tag{5}$$

We analyze $\eta_{\text{construct}}$ (required positions vs. worklist entries) here and η_{compute} (worklist entries vs. issued slots) in §4.4; the factorization decomposes η only, with all stage costs reflected in throughput T.

Because construction tiles partition the output grid and use disjoint reservations, each active coordinate appears exactly once, so $n_{\mathcal{W}} = \|M_{out}\|_0$. Fresh construction therefore has $\eta_{\text{construct}} = 1$ for a nonempty worklist.

WISEConv thus confines its ordering guarantee to each contiguous segment: coordinates retain the tile's dense traversal, while independently reserved segments provide no cross-boundary locality guarantee. A compute tile of B_M positions (the output-position tile width used by the compute stage, §4.4) may therefore span coordinates from multiple construction segments when segments are shorter than B_M; the preserved locality is intra-segment contiguity, not compute-tile-to-construction-tile alignment. As shown in §6.4, this tile-local order achieves compute-stage throughput comparable to global ordering, making the additional ordering pass an unfavorable end-to-end trade-off.

Algorithm 1 Tile-Local Worklist Construction

Require: Input mask M_{in}, output grid $\mathcal{G}$, tile size B_τ
Ensure: Mask M_{out}, worklist $\mathcal{W}$, length $n_{\mathcal{W}} = |\mathcal{W}|$

$n_{\mathcal{W}} \leftarrow 0$
for each $B_\tau \times B_\tau$ spatial tile τ **in parallel do**
  for each position $p \in \tau$ **in parallel do**
    active$(p) \leftarrow \exists r \in \mathcal{N}(p) : M_{in}[r] = 1$
    $M_{out}[p] \leftarrow$ active(p)
  end for
  $\mathcal{P}_\tau \leftarrow$ Compact(τ, M_{out})
  $n_\tau \leftarrow |\mathcal{P}_\tau|$
  base $\leftarrow$ AtomicAdd$(n_{\mathcal{W}}, n_\tau)$
  for each $0 \le j < n_\tau$ **in parallel do**
    $\mathcal{W}[\text{base} + j] \leftarrow \mathcal{P}_\tau[j]$
  end for
end for

4.3 Cross-Operator Worklist Reuse

Each construction pass examines all $H_{out}W_{out}$ positions and, when deriving M_{out} from M_{in}, performs $O(k^2)$ mask work per position. This channel-independent grid scan contrasts with required convolution work, which scales with the active ratio, spatial extent, and both channel dimensions. WISEConv therefore amortizes construction by reusing one worklist across each compatible layer sequence.

For layer l, let $\mathcal{G}^l$ denote its output grid, M^l_{out} its output mask, $\mathcal{W}^l$ its worklist, and $n^l_{\mathcal{W}}$ its device-resident length. WISEConv propagates the mask and worklist metadata alongside the feature tensor. Whether two consecutive layers are reuse-compatible depends on their operator types, not on runtime mask values. An operator that preserves the output grid and does not expand the active set guarantees, for any input mask, that $\mathcal{G}^{l+1} = \mathcal{G}^l$ and

$$\{p \in \mathcal{G}^{l+1} \mid M^{l+1}_{out}[p] = 1\} \subseteq \{p \in \mathcal{G}^l \mid M^l_{out}[p] = 1\}. \quad (6)$$

WISEConv checks this condition once at model-conversion time. Because $\mathcal{W}^l$ covers M^l_{out}, Eq. 6 guarantees coverage for M^{l+1}_{out}. WISEConv therefore forwards $\mathcal{W}^{l+1} = \mathcal{W}^l$ and $n^{l+1}_{\mathcal{W}} = n^l_{\mathcal{W}}$ without reconstruction and applies the condition recursively at each subsequent layer.

Equality in Eq. 6 covers same-grid 1×1 convolutions, mask-preserving activations, and inference-time normalization, leaving $\eta_{\text{construct}}$ unchanged. Strict inclusion can result from mask-narrowing operators in the upstream policy, such as the activation-fused update truncation that DeltaCNN [34] uses to increase downstream sparsity. The inherited worklist remains a valid superset, trading a lower $\eta_{\text{construct}}$ for one fewer construction pass without violating coverage. Because compute gates all output writes by the exact mask, positions scheduled but no longer active under the current mask participate in reduction yet produce no store; the superset schedule therefore cannot alter any inactive position's observable state.

A change in the output grid violates the geometry constraint, while receptive-field expansion may violate Eq. 6 by introducing positions outside the upstream mask; either case invokes the construction pass of §4.2 to emit a new tight worklist. A lower $\eta_{\text{construct}}$ alone does not trigger reconstruction because tightening a valid superset would pay another grid scan. Common receptive-field-expanding layers such as 3×3 convolutions still create rebuild points throughout the network, leaving device-resident worklist lengths variable across layers and frames. Compute must therefore handle a dynamic problem size.

4.4 Worklist-Driven Tiled Compute

4.5 Cost-Aware Tile Selection

5 Implementation

We implement WISEConv as a PyTorch extension with a Python frontend and a CUDA backend written in C++. A model-conversion pass replaces supported modules, preserves their parameters and weights, and statically marks worklist-reuse edges and rebuild points. The compute backend adapts CUTLASS [1] dense tiled implicit-GEMM pipelines for direct worklist consumption, covering both FP32 (SIMT) and FP16 (tensor core) arithmetic with NHWC tensors; the full-workload comparison uses the FP32 datapath, while sensitivity studies additionally exercise the FP16 datapath. The backend covers all convolution variants used by the evaluated models, as well as mask-aware auxiliary operators. The partial-reduction workspace $\mathbf{Z}$ is shared across all layers at the maximum required size and allocated once during initialization. Every backend variant agrees numerically with cuDNN at each active output position.

6 Evaluation

6.1 Experimental Setup

Platforms. We evaluate six GPU platforms. The four discrete GPUs are NVIDIA A100, RTX 4090, RTX 3080, and RTX 4070 Laptop. The embedded platforms are Jetson Xavier NX and AGX Orin; we also measure board energy on both. The discrete platforms use PyTorch 2.1.2, CUDA 12.1, and cuDNN 8.9.2; both Jetson platforms use PyTorch 2.1.0, CUDA 11.4, and cuDNN 8.6. All paths in the full workload comparison use FP32 (SIMT) with TF32 disabled. Sensitivity studies additionally evaluate FP16 (tensor core) on selected platforms. On each platform, all backends run under the same fixed clock and power configuration.

Models, tasks, and mask sources. Our workloads (Table 2) span three vision tasks: FireFlowNet [32] for event-based optical flow on MVSEC [50] with Ev-Conv [10] masks, YOLOv8n and YOLOv8m [22] for detection on MOT16 [29] with DeltaCNN's [34] temporal masks, and DynConv [42] for human pose on MPII [2] with learned spatial gates. For every workload, calibration uses the training split, while all reported results use a disjoint test split with the authors' released weights [22, 32, 42]. Within each workload, we fix inputs, weights, and upstream mask policy; every sparse path receives the same layer masks, isolating the masked-convolution backend.

Table 2. Evaluation workloads.

	FireFlowNet [32]	**YOLOv8n/m** [22]	**DynConv** [42]
Task	Optical flow	Detection	Human pose
Mask source	Ev-Conv [10]	DeltaCNN [34]	DynConv [42]
Dataset	MVSEC [50]	MOT16 [29]	MPII [2]
Input size	256×256	640×640	256×256
Parameters	0.056M	3.16M / 25.9M	6.89M
Eval. samples	196.8K	2,572	2,958

Baselines. We compare WISEConv against three FP32 (SIMT) execution paths: **Dense** (PyTorch/cuDNN [7] with autotuning), **Tile skipping** (DeltaCNN [34] for FireFlowNet and YOLO; DynConv supplies output masks directly), and **Gather-scatter** (DynConv's [42] CUDA backend for pose; MMCV's [6] MaskedConv2d for FireFlowNet and YOLO).

Measurements. We measure per-frame full-model GPU latency over the complete evaluation datasets. CUDA events bracket each frame's inference; after warm-up we run three complete rounds and average per-frame latency across all frames and rounds. The interval includes mask propagation, worklist construction, all network operators, and output update; it excludes input transfer, offline calibration, and one-time initialization. We report η, T, and T_{eff} at the model level by accumulating required and issued work across layers per frame (Eq. 3), then averaging across frames. On the Jetson platforms, we integrate board-level `VDD_IN` power over each frame interval to obtain per-frame energy. For accuracy, we follow the original protocols: AEE for optical flow [10], AP for detection [34], and PCKh for pose [42]. MOT16 AP uses fixed pseudo-labels from a dense YOLO26x teacher [23] because ground-truth detections cover only the training split.

6.2 End-to-End Performance

Latency. WISEConv is the fastest path in all 24 measured workload-platform pairs (Figure 12). Relative to the fastest evaluated competing path in each pair, it achieves a 1.58× geometric-mean speedup; individual-pair speedups range from 1.33× to 2.12×, corresponding to 25.0–52.8% lower latency. Gains span more than two orders of magnitude in absolute latency, from 0.23 ms for FireFlowNet on RTX 4090 to 88.6 ms for YOLOv8m on Xavier NX.

The two existing sparse paths split the remaining 24 pairs between them: dense is fastest in 13 and tile skipping in 11; gather-scatter never wins. The split tracks active ratio: at the YOLO workloads' $\alpha \approx 48$–49%, few tiles are fully inactive, so tile skipping cannot compensate for its lower throughput; on FireFlowNet ($\alpha \approx 25\%$) and DynConv ($\alpha \approx 16\%$), enough tiles are skippable for it to overtake dense. Neither path is uniformly strong, and WISEConv outperforms whichever wins. On the Jetson platforms the lead narrows (geometric mean 1.53× vs. 1.61× on discrete GPUs) but WISEConv remains fastest in all eight pairs.

Across all 24 pairs, WISEConv averages 1.76× the ideal proportional-scaling reference (dashed lines in Figure 12), compared with 2.79× for the per-pair fastest competing path. The gap to ideal tracks active ratio: on the YOLO workloads WISEConv runs at 1.36× ideal, while on DynConv ($\alpha \approx 16\%$) construction and fixed costs widen it to 2.60×.

Energy. WISEConv is the lowest-energy path for every workload on both Jetson platforms (Table 3), reducing energy by 9.3–36.1% relative to the lowest-energy competing path in each pair and by 29.9–67.8% relative to dense execution.

Accuracy. WISEConv's latency and energy gains do not alter accuracy. WISEConv matches the other sparse paths on every workload: AEE and PCKh are identical and YOLOv8 AP differs by at most 0.14 points, a residual of floating-point reduction order rather than any difference in covered positions (Figure 13); even where worklist reuse computes a superset of the required positions, the output mask gates writeback so the extra slots do not reach downstream layers. The remaining accuracy gap between sparse and dense, within 4% across all workloads, is set by the upstream mask policy, which WISEConv consumes without modification.

6.3 Microbenchmarks

Effective throughput. A sparse path lowers latency only if it is both selective, captured by the useful-compute ratio η, and fast, captured by raw throughput T (Eq. 4). Figure 14 reports both, normalized to Dense, on RTX 3080 and AGX Orin, and the two existing paths fail on opposite axes. Tile skipping retains the dense tile schedule and so keeps 41–65% of Dense raw throughput, but an active tile computes every position it covers: its useful-compute ratio falls to 0.45–0.72, wasting 28–55% of the slots it issues. Gather-scatter issues exactly the required positions, giving $\eta = 1$, but extraction and writeback collapse its throughput to 2–47% of Dense. WISEConv is the only path that is high on both axes, sustaining $\eta = 0.90$–1.00 and the highest raw throughput among the sparse paths in every workload—42.0–85.1% of Dense on RTX 3080 and 51.3–86.8% on AGX Orin. The two YOLO workloads lie at the upper end because their higher active ratios expose more parallelism and amortize fixed costs; DeltaCNN's throughput on FireFlowNet and DynConv reflects routing very sparse tiles through its fused selective path [34]. Because effective throughput is the product of the two axes, WISEConv reaches 1.38–2.06× the strongest competing effective throughput on RTX 3080 and 1.47–1.87× on AGX Orin.

Table 3. Per-frame board energy (J) on the Jetson platforms. Parentheses report each sparse path's change relative to Dense.

GPU	System	FireFlowNet	YOLOv8n	YOLOv8m	DynConv
AGX Orin	Dense	0.19	0.34	1.82	1.01
	Tile skip	0.10 (-47.9%)	0.31 (-8.0%)	1.59 (-12.7%)	0.51 (-49.7%)
	Gather	0.27 (+44.8%)	0.62 (+83.9%)	1.88 (+3.3%)	2.49 (+145.5%)
	WISEConv	**0.08** (-58.3%)	**0.22** (-35.6%)	**1.06** (-42.0%)	**0.33** (-67.8%)
Xavier NX	Dense	0.28	0.49	2.57	1.17
	Tile skip	0.14 (-48.7%)	0.41 (-14.9%)	2.31 (-10.2%)	0.60 (-48.7%)
	Gather	0.38 (+36.4%)	0.79 (+63.0%)	2.90 (+12.7%)	3.08 (+163.3%)
	WISEConv	**0.13** (-53.5%)	**0.34** (-29.9%)	**1.78** (-30.8%)	**0.51** (-56.8%)

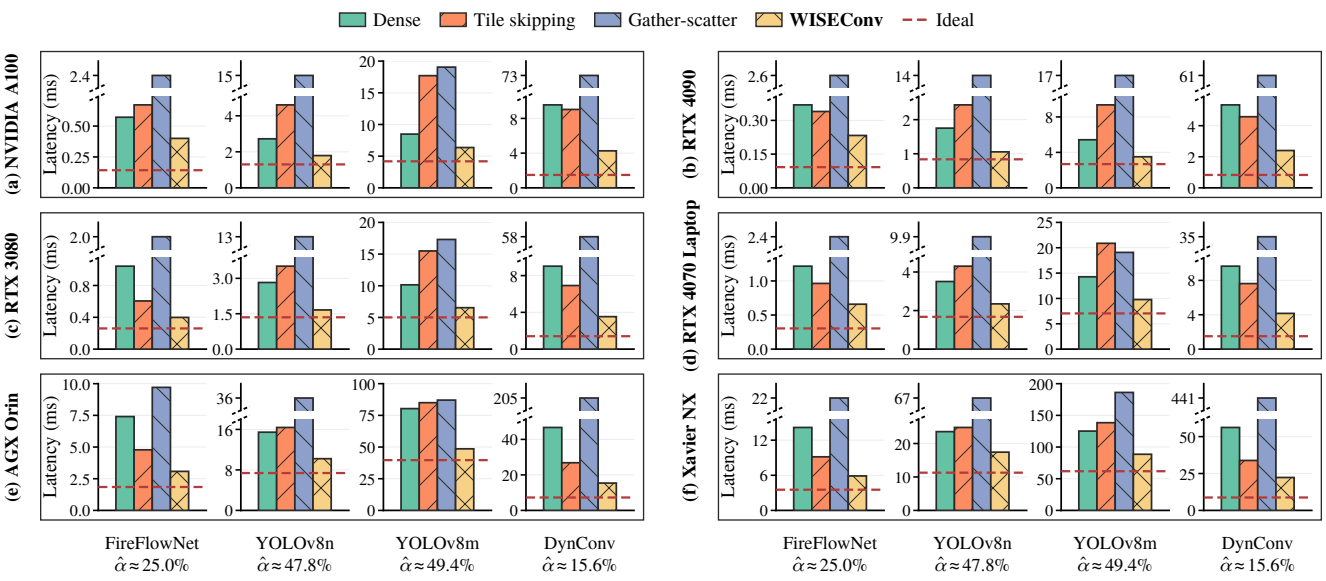


Figure 12. Full-model mean per-frame latency across GPU platforms. Each workload uses an independent y-axis. Labels report the model-level active ratio $\hat{\alpha}$, aggregated as described in §6.1 and averaged across evaluation sequences. Red dashed lines mark ideal proportional scaling, computed by applying each sequence's model-level active ratio to its dense latency before aggregation.

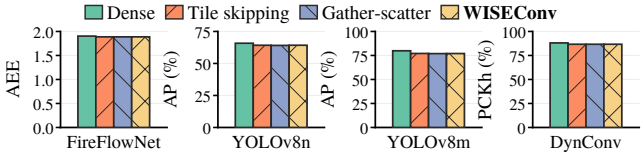


Figure 13. Task accuracy on RTX 3080 under the evaluated upstream sparsity policies, measured by AEE (↓), AP (↑), and PCKh (↑).

Table 4. WISEConv η decomposition and worklist-length statistics on RTX 3080 (FP32; batch 1 unless noted). The $n_{\mathcal{W}}$ percentiles are computed from worklist lengths pooled across all layers and frames.

Workload	$\eta_{\text{construct}}$	η_{compute}	η	$n_{\mathcal{W}}$		
				P10	P50	P90
FireFlowNet	100.0%	99.8%	99.8%	529	13,651	36,009
YOLOv8m	100.0%	92.4%	92.4%	24	261	1,481
YOLOv8m b4	100.0%	98.1%	98.1%	184	1,410	7,256
DynConv	100.0%	92.1%	92.1%	3	43	389

Table 4 localizes WISEConv's own loss on RTX 3080 through the decomposition of Eq. 5. $\eta_{\text{construct}}$, the fraction of worklist entries that are required positions, stays at 98.6–100.0%: tile-local compaction emits each active coordinate exactly once, and only reuse of a superset worklist gives up the remainder. η_{compute}, the fraction of issued slots that are worklist entries, exceeds 99.5% for FireFlowNet and the two YOLO workloads. DynConv is the exception at 90.6%: its low active ratio and small spatial grids yield exceptionally short worklists (P10, P50, and P90 lengths of 3, 43, and 389), so B_M-sized final tiles are mostly padding. Because its inputs are temporally unrelated, DynConv uses the same exact-length device policy without a temporal activity selector. Even at this worst case the total η is more than double tile skipping's 44.8% on the same workload.

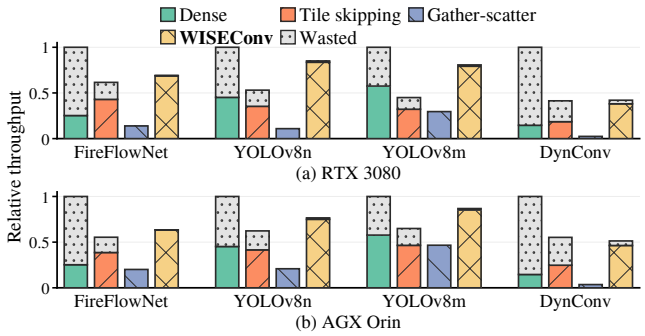


Figure 14. Full-model effective throughput ηT and wasted throughput $(1-\eta)T$ on RTX 3080 and AGX Orin, normalized within each platform to Dense raw throughput.

Latency cost decomposition. We decompose full-model YOLOv8n latency by execution stage on RTX 3080 and AGX

Table 5. Full-model YOLOv8m latency decomposition (batch 1, RTX 3080).

	System	Tot.	Cons.	Conv.	G/S	Other	Idle
FP32	Dense	10.76	—	9.68 (90)	—	1.08 (10)	—
	Tile skipping	12.51	—	11.70 (94)	—	0.81 (6)	—
	Gather-scatter	12.74	0.37 (3)	1.68 (13)	1.58 (12)	0.84 (7)	8.26 (65)
	WISEConv	3.00	0.17 (6)	2.27 (76)	—	0.56 (19)	—
FP16	Dense	3.80	—	2.69 (71)	—	1.11 (29)	—
	WISEConv	1.44	0.15 (10)	0.88 (61)	—	0.42 (29)	—

Notes. Entries are milliseconds per frame; parenthesized numbers are percentages of each row's total, the whole-video end-to-end latency. Stages are the kernels' shares of the GPU busy time (nsys); Cons. is the worklist construction (gather-scatter's mask compaction), G/S gather-scatter's feature extraction and scatter, Other the remaining operators; Idle is the GPU idle time within the frame (host synchronization). The baselines have no FP16 implementation.

Orin (Table 5). On RTX 3080, WISEConv reduces the convolution share from 2.32 to 0.99 ms (2.3×, close to the $1/\alpha \approx 2.2$ proportional target) while adding 0.12 ms of construction, lowering the total from 2.82 to 1.66 ms. On AGX Orin the convolution reduction is 2.0× (11.91 to 6.06 ms) at 0.51 ms of construction, and the total falls from 15.45 to 10.22 ms.

Gather-scatter is the exception: it issues exactly the required positions, so its convolution is the smallest share of any path (30% of its total), but extraction, scatter, and buffer setup cost 7.48 ms, 59% of its total, on RTX 3080. Exact selection alone does not lower latency without a fused datapath.

Memory overhead. Table 6 reports peak live GPU allocation. FireFlowNet, YOLOv8n, and YOLOv8m use temporal mask policies that retain previous-frame activations for differencing, so every sparse path allocates 3–4× Dense. The temporal state dominates the gap, and WISEConv stays within the same tier as tile skipping; gather-scatter is the exception on YOLOv8m, where materializing input patches for each active position adds to the temporal state and pushes it above both other sparse paths. DynConv applies learned spatial gates without temporal state, placing all backends in a narrow 27–34 MiB range. Here WISEConv's worklist and coordinate metadata add only 2.3 MiB over Dense, while gather-scatter is the most compact because DynConv's predominantly pointwise block structure lets intermediates stay in the gathered compact representation [42].

Table 6. Peak live GPU allocation (MiB) on RTX 3080 (FP32; batch 1 unless noted).

System	FireFlowNet	YOLOv8m	YOLOv8m b4	DynConv
Dense	33.9	182.0	432.2	56.8
Tile skipping	141.8	751.0	2701.0	53.8
Gather-scatter	197.0	834.8	2737.0	57.2
WISEConv	128.6	763.9	2730.4	56.9

Table 7. Co-design ablation on YOLOv8m (batch 1, RTX 3080, FP16). Each variant replaces one mechanism and keeps the weights, inputs, upstream masks and every other component. Cons. and Conv. are the construction- and compute-stage GPU kernel time (ms); Tot. is the full-model latency (ms, aligned to the whole-video end-to-end latency of Ours); × is relative to Ours unless noted.

	Variant	Cons.	Conv.	Tot.	×
Cons.	No reuse	0.30	0.86	1.59	1.10
Comp.	Shuffled order	0.15	0.92	—	1.04†
	Readback & launch	—	—	9.40	6.51
	Full-layer grid	0.15	1.06	1.63	1.13†
Sel.	Dense-tuned tile	0.16	1.89	2.47	1.71
	Best single tile	0.16	0.88	1.47	1.02
	Latency-optimal tile	0.16	1.00	1.59	1.10
	Cost-unaware $K_{\max}$	0.22	0.85	1.55	1.07
	Zero-cost oracle	—	—	1.32	0.92
	Ours	0.16	0.86	1.44	1.00

Variants. No reuse: rebuild the worklist at every layer. *Shuffled order*: permute each worklist on the device before the compute stage (permutation not counted; convolution time). *Readback & launch*: read n_W back to the host per layer and launch the exact grid. *Full-layer grid*: launch the dense layer's grid; CTAs beyond the worklist exit. *Dense-tuned / Best single / Latency-optimal tile*: Ours' candidate structure (the same layers, candidate counts and thresholds), every candidate the tile fastest at α=1, with the best expected speedup, or with the lowest expected latency (uniform n_W). *Cost-unaware* $K_{\max}$: up to four candidates at every layer, ignoring their cost. *Zero-cost oracle*: those candidates, each frame on a graph captured for its own n_W, with no selection mechanism. †Relative to the best single tile without the selection mechanism.

6.4 Ablation Study and Sensitivity Analysis

Table 7 isolates each co-designed component by disabling it while holding all others fixed on YOLOv8n; the stage decomposition separates the effect on construction and convolution.

Construction. On RTX 3080, Atomic append and Global order raise construction from 0.12 to 0.43 and 0.54 ms without reducing convolution (0.94 ms throughout), adding 19.1% and 19.6% to the end-to-end latency over Ours; Global order's higher construction reflects its additional kernel passes. No reuse *raises* η to 99.7% ($\eta_{\text{construct}} = 1$ per layer) but increases construction 1.6× (0.12 to 0.19 ms), adding 5.7% over Ours: rebuilding the worklist every layer is more expensive than reusing a slightly loose superset worklist. On AGX Orin the same pattern holds with smaller margins: construction variants add 1–9% over Ours while convolution stays within 0.05 ms, because convolution is a larger share of the total.

Compute. On RTX 3080, DP only raises convolution from 0.94 to 1.01 ms over Ours (+0.07 ms); No hybrid, which retains full Stream-K but not the hybrid mode, recovers most of that gap (0.96 ms, +0.02 ms over Ours). Readback & launch runs the same kernels as Ours but adds per-operator host synchronization, inflating the total from 1.66 to 7.61 ms (4.58×

Ours). On AGX Orin, DP only adds 1.5% end-to-end latency over Ours and readback inflates it to 2.38× Ours.

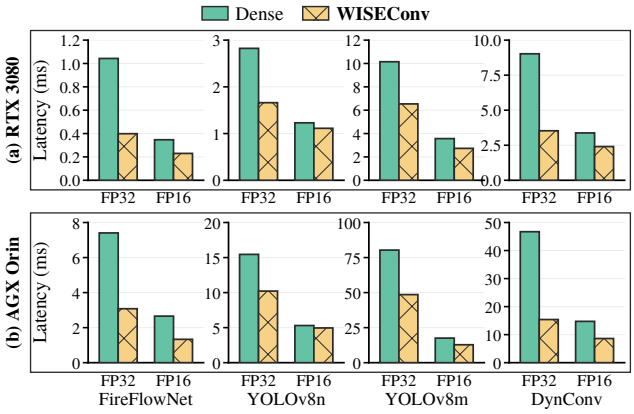


Figure 15. FP32 (SIMT) vs. FP16 (tensor core) full-model latency for Dense and WISEConv across all four workloads on RTX 3080 and AGX Orin.

Tensor core sensitivity. Figure 15 compares FP32 and FP16 execution on RTX 3080 and AGX Orin. The evaluated sparse baselines [6, 34, 42] provide only FP32 paths, so this study compares Dense and WISEConv only. WISEConv retains a 1.07–1.99× speedup over Dense under FP16 tensor cores across all eight workload-platform pairs, narrowing from 1.51–3.04× under FP32. The narrowing is expected: tensor cores reduce the convolution time that WISEConv saves by skipping, shrinking the absolute saving while non-convolution costs (construction, elementwise, mask processing) do not shrink proportionally. The two YOLO workloads narrow the most (1.51–1.70× under FP32 to 1.07–1.37× under FP16) because their high active ratio ($\alpha \approx 48$–49%) already limits the sparsity gain; within the two, YOLOv8n narrows further because its smaller model makes non-convolution costs a larger share of the total under FP16.

Stream-level batching. Table 8 reports per-frame latency decomposition for YOLOv8n on RTX 3080 at batch sizes 1, 4, and 8. WISEConv remains fastest at every batch size, but its lead over the fastest competing path narrows from 1.70× at batch 1 to 1.59× at batch 8. Tile skipping benefits most: from batch 1 to 8, its per-frame convolution drops from 2.89 to 0.92 ms, compared with 0.99 to 0.49 ms for WISEConv, because batching adds independent tiles that fill otherwise idle SMs [34], the same occupancy that WISEConv's adaptive decomposition already provides at batch 1. Tile skipping accordingly overtakes dense at batch 4 and stays the fastest competing path at batch 8. Gather-scatter's extraction overhead does not amortize: *Other* still accounts for 59.4% of its per-frame latency at batch 8.

Table 8. YOLOv8m latency decomposition under stream-level batching (RTX 3080, FP32). Each batch combines one current frame of each of B disjoint temporal streams; times are per frame. Stage definitions and cell format follow Table 5.

	System	Tot.	Cons.	Conv.	G/S	Other	Idle
B=1	Dense	10.76	—	9.68 (90)	—	1.08 (10)	—
	Tile skipping	12.51	—	11.70 (94)	—	0.81 (6)	—
	Gather-scatter	12.74	0.37 (3)	1.68 (13)	1.58 (12)	0.84 (7)	8.26 (65)
	WISEConv	3.00	0.17 (6)	2.27 (76)	—	0.56 (19)	—
B=4	Dense	11.04	—	9.90 (90)	—	1.12 (10)	0.02 (0)
	Tile skipping	5.04	—	4.46 (88)	—	0.59 (12)	—
	Gather-scatter	4.50	0.13 (3)	1.42 (32)	1.50 (33)	0.56 (12)	0.89 (20)
	WISEConv	1.88	0.05 (3)	1.49 (79)	—	0.33 (18)	0.01 (0)

6.5 Discussion

Limitations. WISEConv converts spatial sparsity into latency, so its benefit is bounded by how sparse the upstream masks are and by how much of the frame convolution occupies. First, the gain vanishes as the active ratio approaches one: at full activity the per-length best configuration only matches dense execution (§3.1) while construction still runs, so a fully active input runs slightly slower than the dense path. WISEConv consumes masks and makes no claim about their quality or the resulting accuracy; a policy that keeps most positions active should stay on the dense path. Second, WISEConv accelerates convolution only, so convolution's share of frame latency caps the end-to-end speedup. FP16 tensor cores shrink that share, and the remaining non-convolution operators become the next bottleneck, which is why FP16 speedups are narrower than FP32 ones (§6.3). Models dominated by other operators bound the gain further.

Hardware implications. The characterization traces the remaining gap to two per-layer costs that current GPUs leave to software. The intercept of the affine model is launch and dependency latency rather than lost bandwidth (Insight 4), and its share grows as inputs become sparser; hardware that shortens the path from launch to the first useful instruction (for example, by staging kernel parameters before the CTA starts) and the dependent chain of a single tile would move sparse execution toward the proportional line. Following the worklist length costs about as much per decision point as it gains (Insight 5), because every existing mechanism either returns to the host or reconfigures the graph. A launch predicate that the hardware evaluates on a device-resident value before allocating CTA resources, or a work distributor that picks the tile shape from the worklist length, would let every layer adapt its configuration at negligible cost.

7 Conclusion

We presented WISEConv, a masked-convolution runtime that replaces the dense tiled pipeline's contiguous coordinate stream with an active-output worklist, computing almost exclusively the positions an upstream mask requires while retaining the dense tensor layout and the regular per-position reduction. The construction and consumption stages are co-designed to secure both useful-compute ratio and throughput; our ablation confirms that disabling any single mechanism degrades one axis without improving the other. The resulting higher effective throughput lets WISEConv convert upstream mask sparsity into proportional latency and energy reduction for the latency-critical vision tasks where masked convolution applies.

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